

Ancient Egypt

One of the longest-lasting civilizations in history, ancient Egypt was also one of the most stable. It lasted for more than 3,000 years after its foundation in around 3100 BCE, while empires rose and fell in the Middle East. Throughout this period, Egyptians spoke the same language, and followed the same seasonal routine based on the annual flooding of the Nile River.

The Egyptians called their country *Kemet*, meaning “black land.” The name came from the fertile black silt left behind every year when the Nile River flooded. The flood water went down at exactly the right time of year to plant crops, making the land perfect for farming.

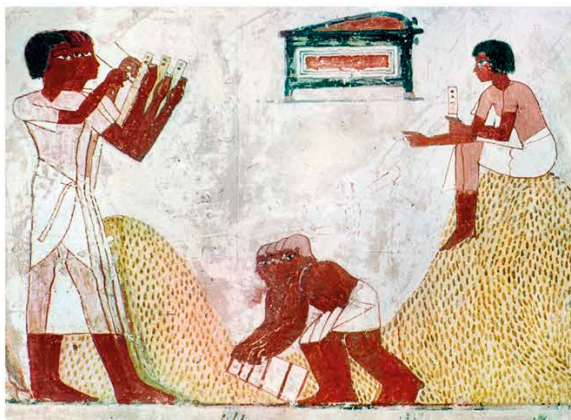
After 3600 BCE, societies in the region developed into two kingdoms—Upper Egypt in the south and Lower Egypt in the north. The two were united around 3100 BCE by a pharaoh (ruler) called Narmer. This unified civilization was at its height during three periods: the

Old Kingdom (c. 2682–c. 2182 BCE), the Middle Kingdom (c. 2055–c. 1650 BCE), and the New Kingdom (c. 1550–c. 1069 BCE). While pharaohs of the first two periods built pyramid tombs, later pharaohs were buried in secret tombs in the desert. New Kingdom pharaohs were also warriors and created an empire stretching from the Euphrates River in Asia in the north to Nubia in the south.



▲ GIFT OF THE NILE

The Nile River flowed north through the desert, creating a green, fertile strip where Egyptians built their cities and farmed the land. The deserts that extended on either side protected Egypt from most foreign invaders.



▲ KEEPING RECORDS

The Egyptians invented one of the first writing systems, known as hieroglyphics, around 3300 BCE. It used hundreds of picture signs representing words, sounds, and ideas. Above, scribes are shown taking records of the size of the harvest.

